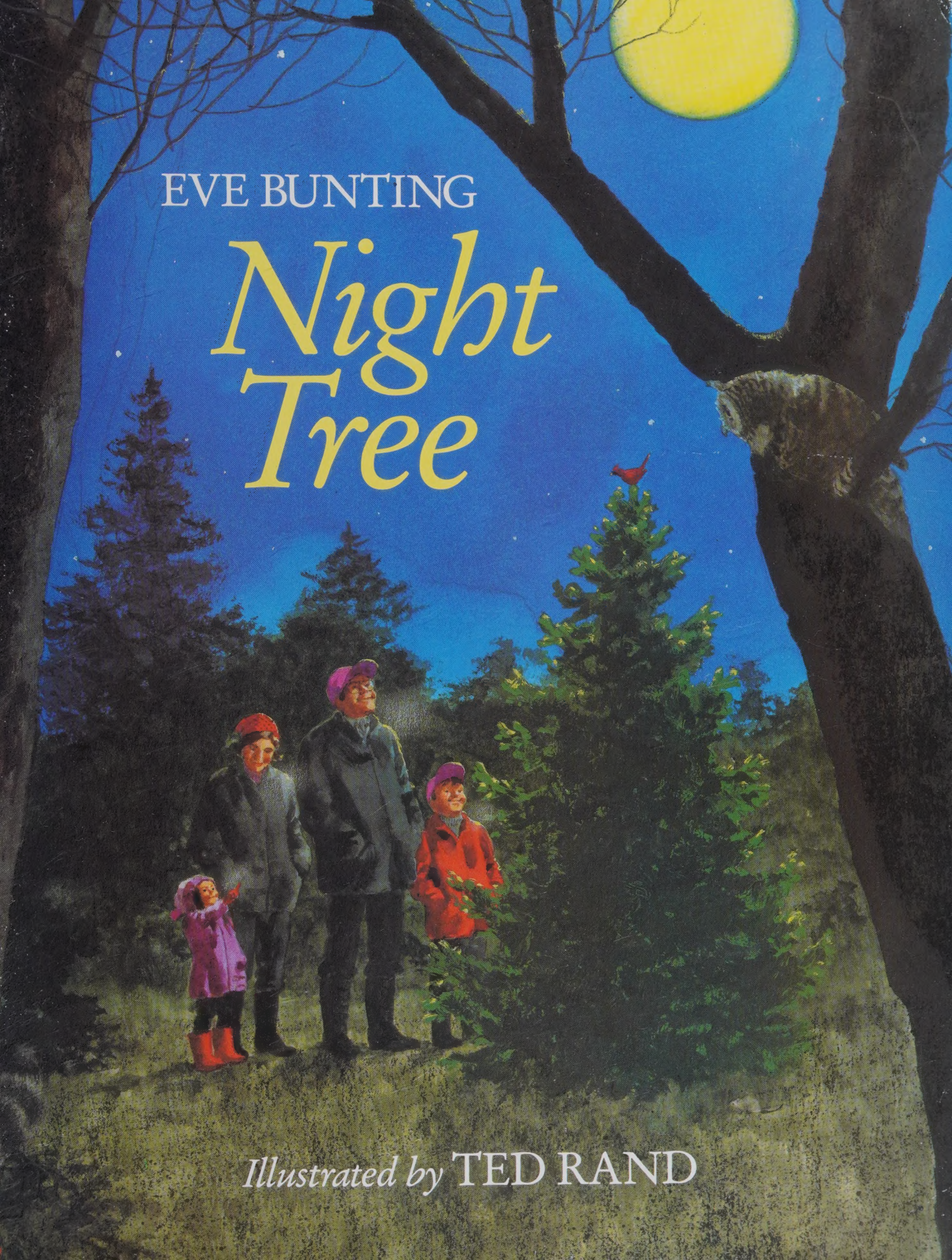




EVE BUNTING

Night Tree

Illustrated by TED RAND



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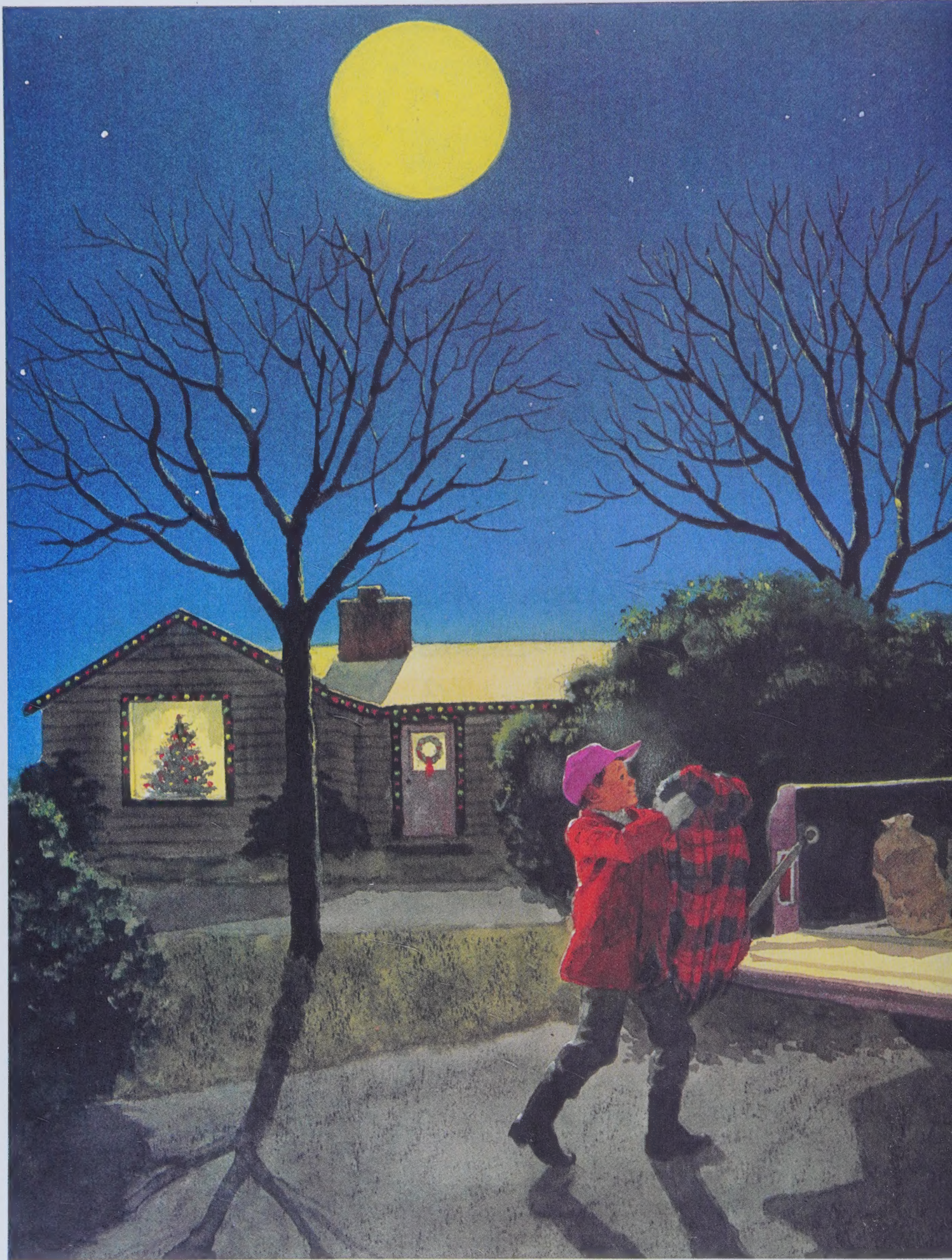
Night Tree

THE WOODS ARE FILLED
WITH WONDROUS SECRETS!

Eve Bunting

1994

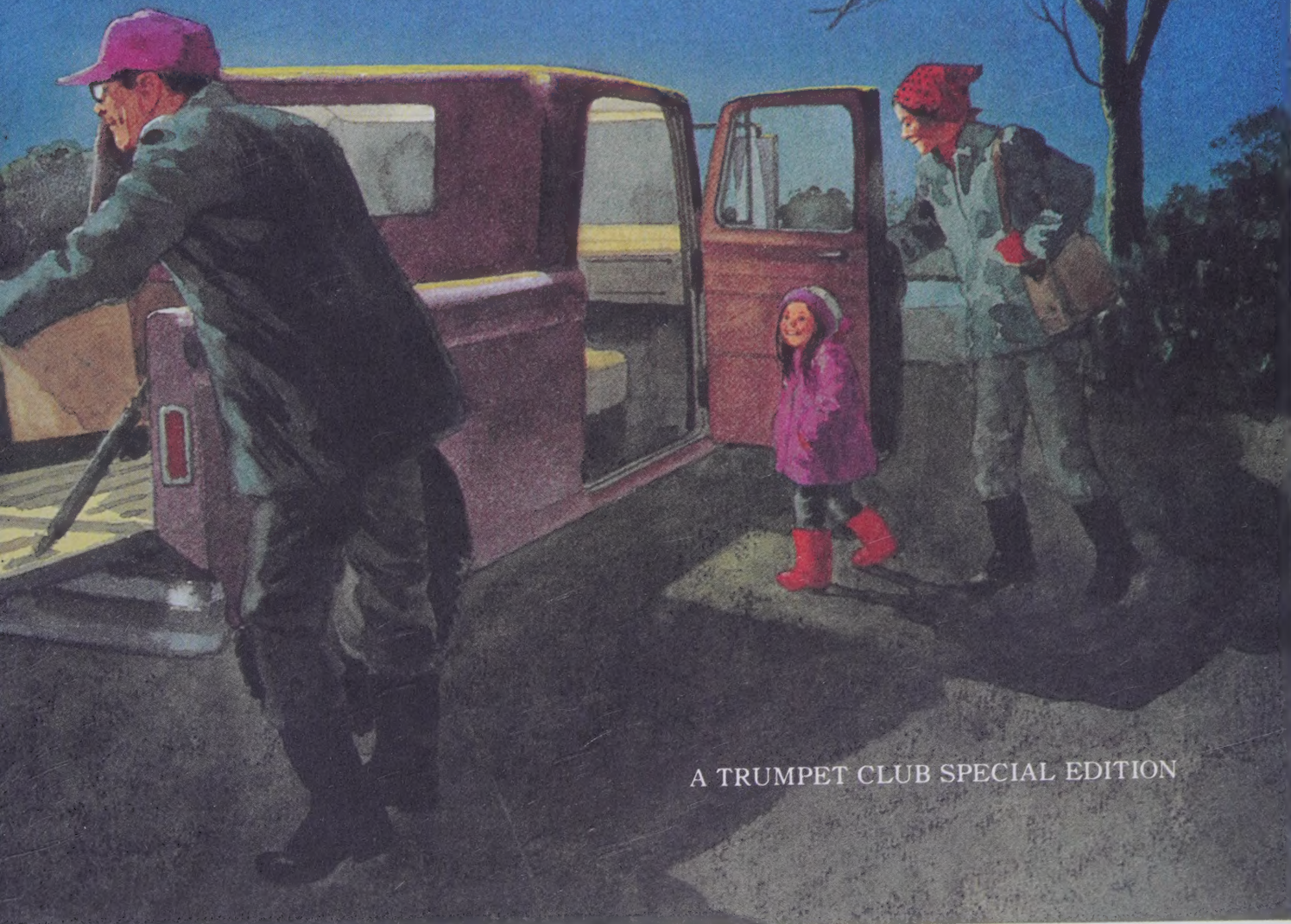
*To a green and
Peaceful planet—
Ted Rand 1994*



EVE BUNTING

Night Tree

Illustrated by
TED RAND



A TRUMPET CLUB SPECIAL EDITION



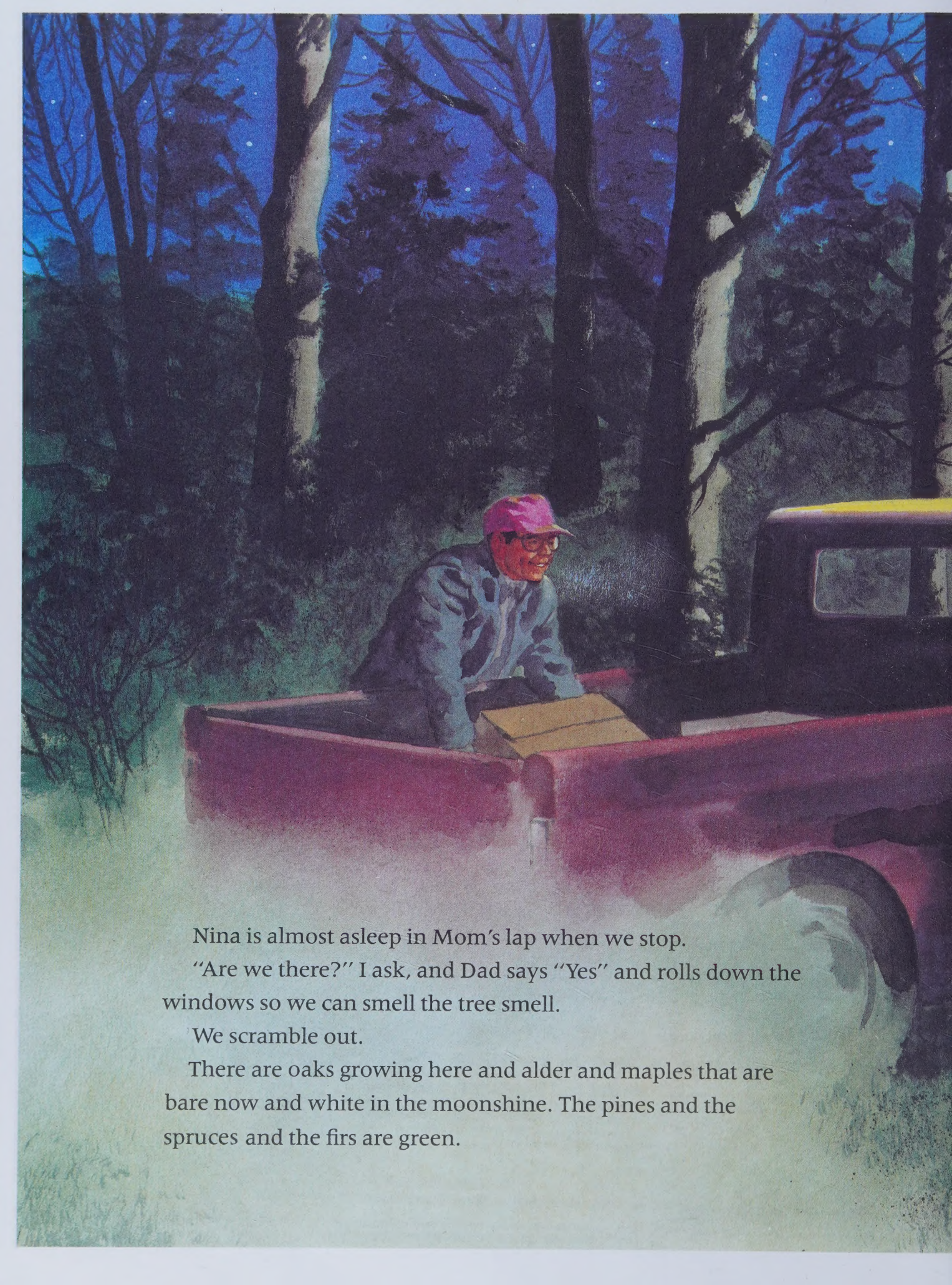
O n the night before Christmas we always go to find our tree.

We bundle up so we're warm. Nina is already wearing her boots that are too big for her. She has been wearing them all day.

Dad sets our box in the back of the truck with the rest of his stuff and the four of us squish into the front seat.

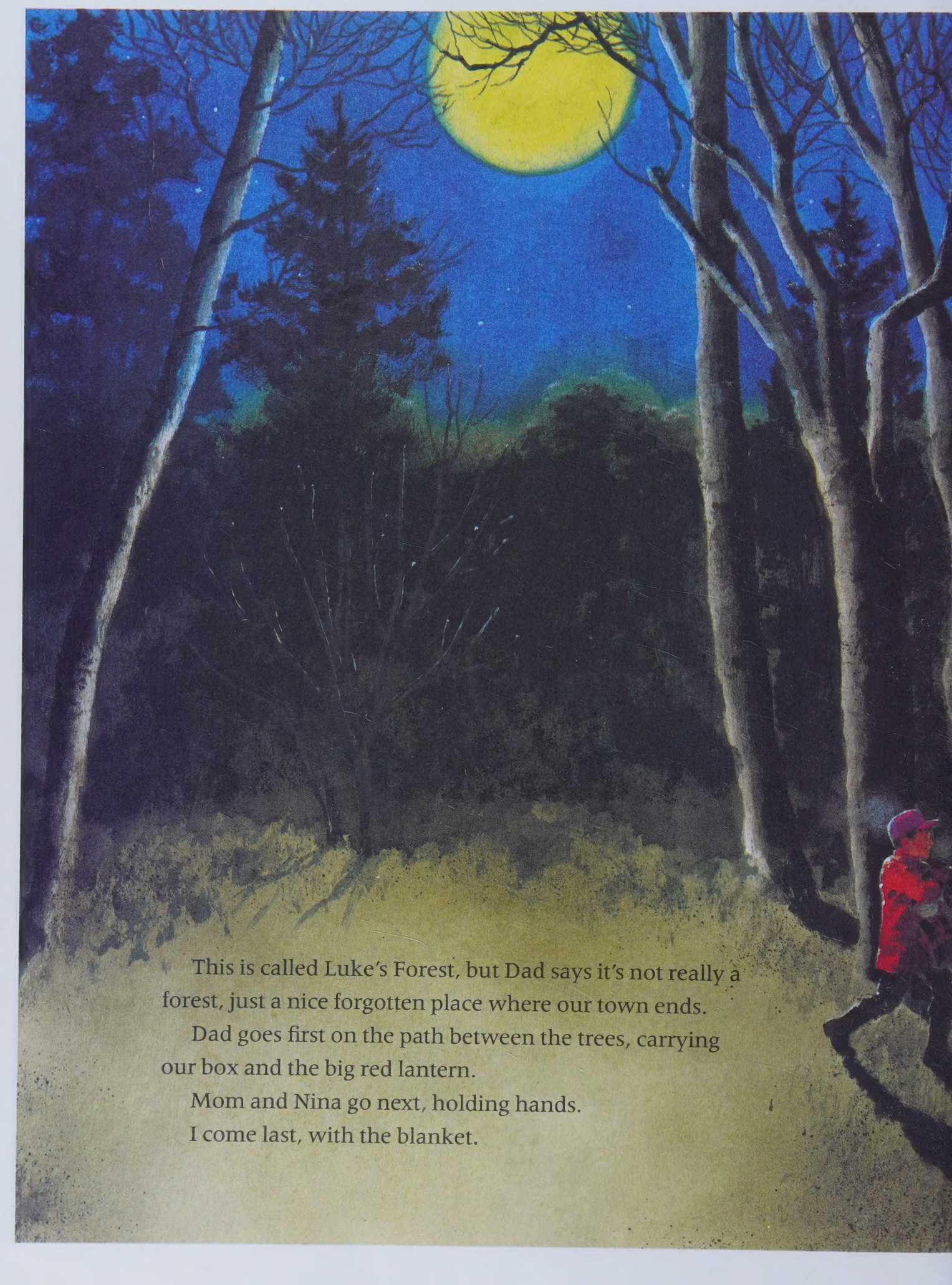
We drive through the bright Christmas streets to where the dark and quiet begin.



A man wearing a red jacket and a red cap is sitting in the back of a red pickup truck. He is smiling and looking towards the right. The truck is parked in a forest at night. The trees are dark, and the sky is a deep blue. The ground is covered in a layer of snow or frost. The man is holding a cardboard box in his lap. The truck's bed is visible, and the back of the cab is on the right side of the frame.

Nina is almost asleep in Mom's lap when we stop.
"Are we there?" I ask, and Dad says "Yes" and rolls down the windows so we can smell the tree smell.
We scramble out.
There are oaks growing here and alder and maples that are bare now and white in the moonshine. The pines and the spruces and the firs are green.





This is called Luke's Forest, but Dad says it's not really a forest, just a nice forgotten place where our town ends.

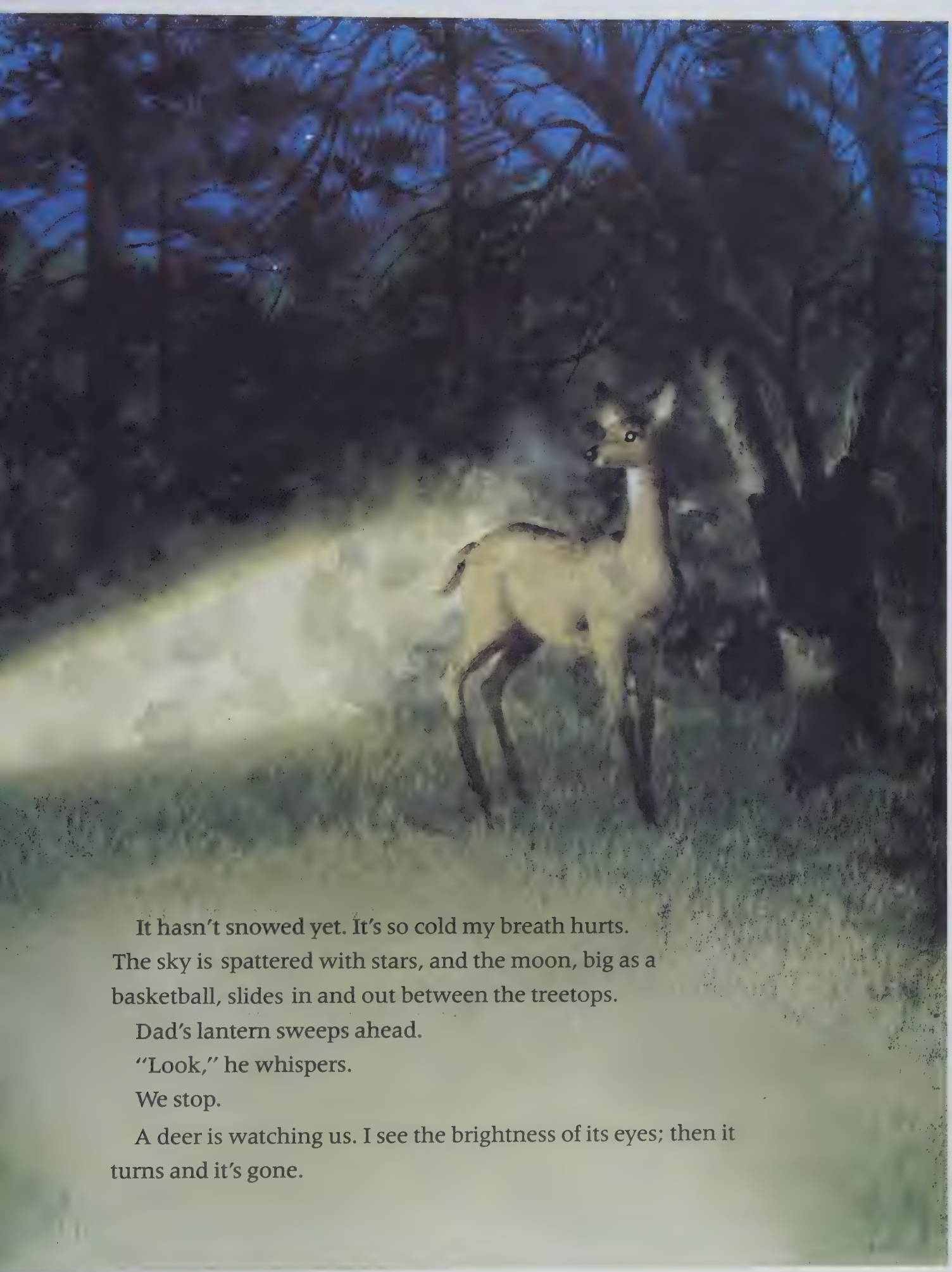
Dad goes first on the path between the trees, carrying our box and the big red lantern.

Mom and Nina go next, holding hands.

I come last, with the blanket.







It hasn't snowed yet. It's so cold my breath hurts.
The sky is spattered with stars, and the moon, big as a
basketball, slides in and out between the treetops.

Dad's lantern sweeps ahead.

"Look," he whispers.

We stop.

A deer is watching us. I see the brightness of its eyes; then it
turns and it's gone.

A man wearing a red hat, a blue jacket, and red gloves stands in a forest. He is looking towards a large, dark tree trunk. On the ground next to him is a gift wrapped in red and green plaid paper, and a brown cardboard box. The forest is dense with tall trees and the ground is covered in dry leaves.

"Here's our tree," Dad says.
It has been our tree forever and ever. We walk
around it, touching it.
"It's grown since last year," I say.
Mom puts her hand on my shoulder. "So have you."
"So have I," Nina says. Nina hates to be left out.





An owl hoots, deep in the darkness.
There are secrets all around us.





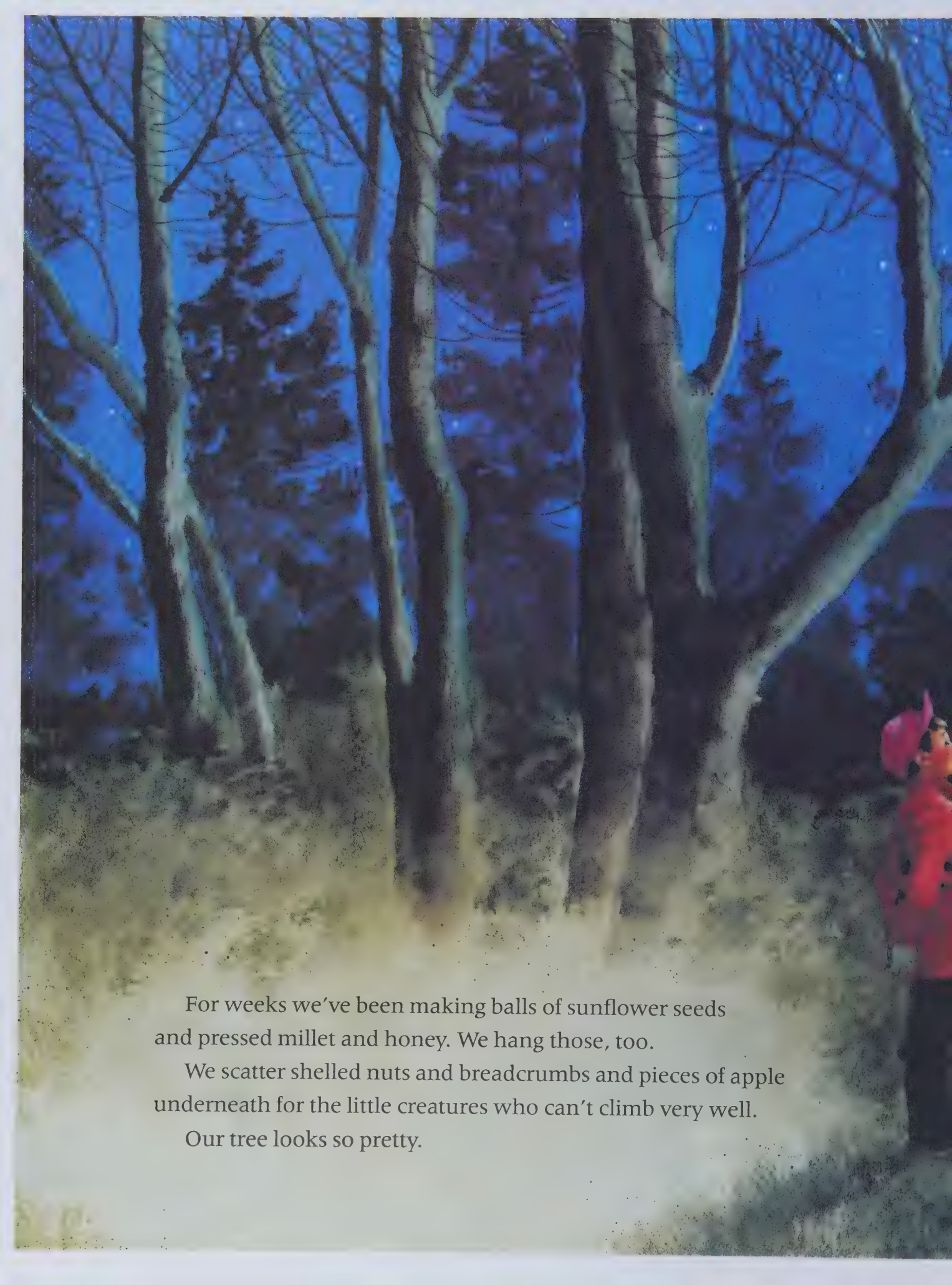


"Can I put on the popcorn chain?" Nina asks. She hops up and down and right out of one of her boots. Mom helps her get it back on.

A young girl with blonde hair, wearing a bright pink knit hat and a vibrant red winter coat, is shown from the side, looking up and reaching towards a green evergreen tree. She is holding a long, white, beaded string, which she is about to hang on the tree. The tree is already decorated with several red apples and orange tangerines, each with a white string tied around its stem. The background is a clear blue sky, suggesting a bright, sunny day. The overall scene is festive and captures a moment of holiday preparation.

Nina takes one end of the chain and I take the other and we wind it around our tree. We've brought apples and tangerines with strings on them, and we hang them from the branches. It's hard to hang string loops when you have gloves on, but it's too cold to take them off.





For weeks we've been making balls of sunflower seeds
and pressed millet and honey. We hang those, too.

We scatter shelled nuts and breadcrumbs and pieces of apple
underneath for the little creatures who can't climb very well.

Our tree looks so pretty.





Mom says I should spread the blanket so we can sit and admire our tree. She has brought a thermos of hot chocolate. I take off my gloves and toast my hands around my warm cup.

Dad turns off the lantern and we stay quiet, hoping some of the little animals will come while we're here, hoping the deer will come back. But it doesn't.

"It's shy," Dad says. "I'm shy, too," Nina tells him.





Before we leave she and I get to choose a Christmas carol to sing. I choose "Oh Come, all ye Faithful."

Nina chooses "Old MacDonald Had a Farm."

"That's not a Christmas song, silly," I tell her, but Mom says it's fine and a very nice song, too.

We sing fast because there are a lot of verses and it's getting colder.







After the last "E-I-O" we gather up our things and head for the truck.

I look back once.

Our tree has folded itself into the darkness, but I think I can see it still, stars caught in its branches and the moon swinging lopsided on top.

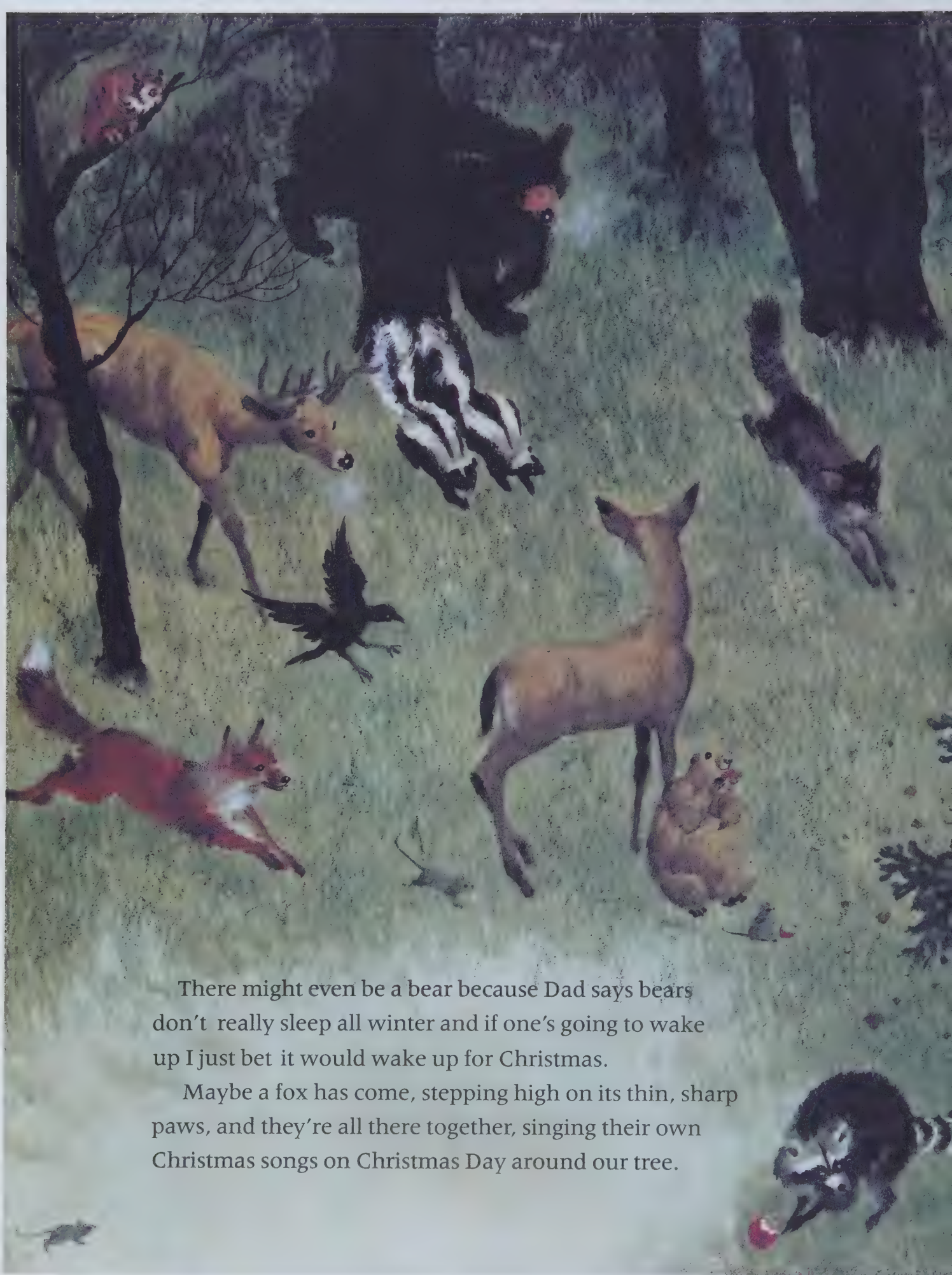
Nina gets tired and Dad has to wrap her in the blanket and carry her. I carry her boots.



Later, in bed, I think about our tree, and sometimes, next day, when the aunts and the uncles and the cousins are at our house and it's noisy and happy, I let my mind go back to Luke's Forest.

I think of the birds having Christmas dinner and the squirrels and the opossums and the raccoons and the skunks.





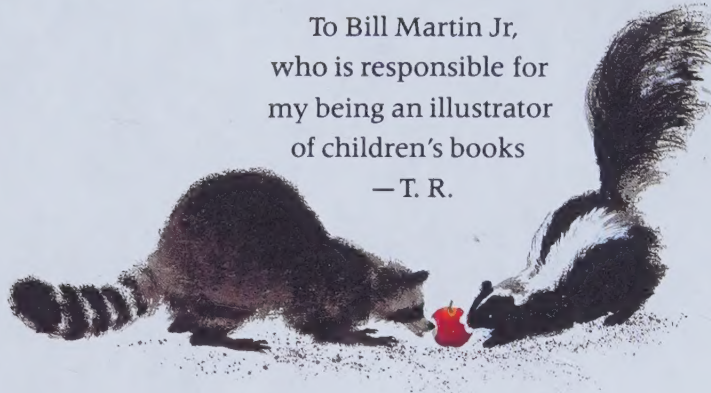
There might even be a bear because Dad says bears don't really sleep all winter and if one's going to wake up I just bet it would wake up for Christmas.

Maybe a fox has come, stepping high on its thin, sharp paws, and they're all there together, singing their own Christmas songs on Christmas Day around our tree.



To Anna Eve,
our palindrome girl
— E. B.

To Bill Martin Jr,
who is responsible for
my being an illustrator
of children's books
— T. R.



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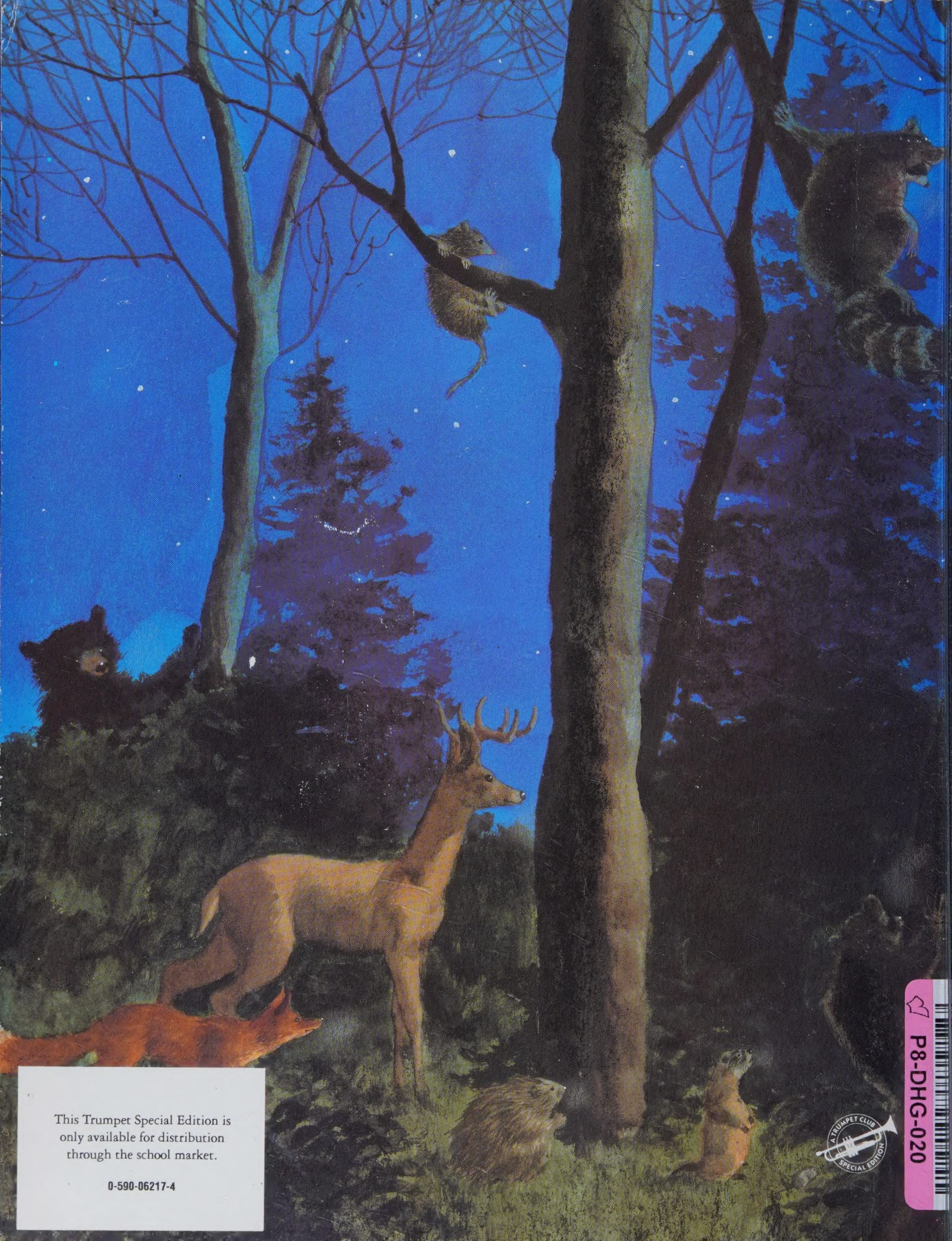
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